

A master of guerrilla warfare and one of the great military minds of the 20th century, General Vo Nguyen Giap piloted the Vietnamese resistance to the Japanese invasion during World War II, spearheaded the military insurrection against the French colonists in the 1950s, and led NVA and Viet Cong efforts against the US and its allies during the Vietnam War. He was also active in politics, serving as defense minister, deputy prime minister, and a member of the Communist Party Politburo.

Giap grew up in a staunchly anticolonial household. His father took part in early uprisings against the French and later died in prison after his arrest for subversive activities. One of Giap's sisters also died as a political prisoner and his first wife would perish in a French colonial prison. These events had a profound effect on Giap's world view and political leanings.